

Kennedy Push
Studies Harms
From Vaccines

Experts Wary of Intent
for Research Plan

By SHERYL GAY STOLBERG

WASHINGTON — Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr., who has long questioned the safety of vaccines, is planning a broad federal effort to address vaccine injuries, including a new research clinic at the National Institutes of Health and a new billing code to reimburse doctors for filing reports of serious vaccine side effects, according to multiple people familiar with the initiative.

Mr. Kennedy talked about the initiative when he and other top health officials made an unannounced visit to the N.I.H. in Bethesda, Md., this week — his first trip there as secretary — to meet with patients who said they believed they had been injured by vaccines, according to the people, who insisted on anonymity because they were not authorized to discuss it.

Officials at the Department of Health and Human Services did not respond to requests for comment about the initiative. A spokesman for Dr. Jay Bhattacharya, the N.I.H. director, declined comment. Some details of the initiative were earlier reported by Bloomberg.

Mr. Kennedy’s efforts to focus government resources on vaccine injuries comes as vaccine-preventable diseases, including measles, are rising in the United States because of falling vaccination rates.

Like all drugs, vaccines cause side effects, but public health experts say the benefits far outweigh the risks for most people. The World Health Organization estimated in 2024 that global immunization efforts had saved 154 million lives over the past half-century. Vaccines have wiped out smallpox and relegated polio mostly to the history books.

Although injuries are rare, vaccine experts generally support close monitoring and continued study of side effects. Many are wary of Mr. Kennedy’s motivations, however, and they say that until more details of the initiative

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TYLER HICKS/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Life Under Constant Attack
The site of a Russian strike in Sloviansk in eastern Ukraine in July. Another attack hit the region Thursday, killing dozens. Page A6.

5 Women Detail the Scars of Hollywood Smears

By DEBRA KAMIN

In recent years, at least five women have filed lawsuits describing malicious public relations campaigns intended to destroy their reputations.

While the lawsuits differ, they all claim the smear campaigns were carried out through anonymous websites, fabricated social media posts or promotion of unflattering articles and posts on the internet. They describe a new lane in the field of crisis management where public relations, legal services and the dark web converge.

The highest-profile lawsuit came from the actress Blake Lively, who said a campaign was waged against her in 2024 in retaliation for accusing the actor Justin Baldoni of sexual harassment. Mr. Baldoni denied the

Suits Say Small Group
Fueled Campaigns
on Social Media

claims and filed a countersuit, which was dismissed.

Ms. Lively settled this year with no payout of damages, but Mr. Baldoni was required to pay her more than \$400,000 in attorney fees. In her lawsuit, Ms. Lively described a coordinated social media campaign orchestrated by three businesspeople — a Los Angeles lawyer, a New York publicist and a Texas digital strategist.

To examine the allegations, The New York Times interviewed more than 60 people, reviewed court documents and chat transcripts, and analyzed hundreds of

anonymous websites and fabricated social media profiles. A pattern emerged.

The campaigns were launched within months of each other and were designed to be untraceable, but digital bread crumbs remained: The same language echoed across multiple websites, and invisible links drove traffic back and forth among them. Text messages and legal depositions filed as part of lawsuits support the allegations that all three individuals were working together.

The lawyer, Bryan Freedman; the publicist, Melissa Nathan; and the digital strategist, Jed Wallace, have dismissed the allegations as defamation and harassment, and in several cases have countersued to clear their names.

The Times sent detailed requests for comment to Ms. Na-

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Newsom Mulls
Saving All 563
On Death Row

By LAUREL ROSENHALL

SACRAMENTO — Gov. Gavin Newsom, a possible presidential candidate, is seriously considering whether to spare the lives of all 563 prisoners on death row in California as one of his final acts in office, according to two people familiar with his thinking.

Mr. Newsom ramped up conversations with top advisers last week after a botched execution in Tennessee, though he had been deliberating the move for several months. He discussed his options in a flurry of phone calls, meetings and Zoom conversations, according to people familiar with the talks who spoke anonymously because they were not authorized to disclose private deliberations.

California has not executed a prisoner in 20 years, and the leading candidate to succeed Mr. Newsom has committed to maintaining a moratorium on capital punishment. A mass commutation, however, would reduce all current death sentences to life in prison without parole, regardless of who runs the state in the future.

The governor, a Democrat, has received conflicting advice from his closest advisers, the people said. Some have urged him to take a bold step that reflects his moral opposition to capital punishment before he leaves office in January. Others have warned that he could

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Politics in Mind,
Estranged Wife
Sticks by Paxton

By BETH REINHARD
and LISA LERER

Again and again, throughout his long political career, Ken Paxton has gotten himself into trouble. Each time, his wife, Angela, has come to his defense.

In 2022, a process server trying to deliver a subpoena to Mr. Paxton, the Republican attorney general of Texas, said he watched Ms. Paxton drive him away from their home in a truck.

The next year, during Mr. Paxton’s impeachment trial, which aired multiple allegations of corruption and an extramarital affair, Ms. Paxton, a Republican state senator, sat stoically through the entire proceedings, which she later dismissed in a social media post as “all of this foolishness.”

And now, in the homestretch of the 2026 campaign, with polls showing Mr. Paxton trailing the Democrat James Talarico in the U.S. Senate race, Ms. Paxton is urging voters in a new television ad to back the entire Republican ticket — even as she is divorcing her husband and accusing him of adultery.

It is not just Mr. Paxton’s political future at stake. It is also her own.

Ms. Paxton, 63, has tried to

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MARGARET HAMILTON, 1936-2026

She Stacked 1s and 0s That Reached the Moon

By TRIP GABRIEL

Margaret Hamilton, who led the 100-person team that wrote the onboard software for the Apollo missions, guiding Neil Armstrong and Buzz Aldrin to a safe landing on the moon, died on Sept. 30 in Cambridge, Mass. She was 90.

Her death, in a hospital, was confirmed by her daughter, Lauren.

Ms. Hamilton was a young mathematician at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology in the early 1960s, putting her husband through law school by working in a computer lab. When she learned that M.I.T. was designing in-flight computers for the moon mission, she eagerly joined the team.

She was the first female programmer hired to work on the Apollo project, housed at M.I.T.’s Instrumentation Laboratory, in 1965. Her skills led to her promotion to director of software engineering on the project, which developed the two 70-pound onboard computers for the Apollo flights: one in the command module, which carried the astronauts from Earth, and the second in the lunar module, which set down on the moon’s surface.

Ms. Hamilton, who would bring her young daughter to work on weekends and evenings, is credited

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NASA ARCHIVE/ALAMY

Margaret Hamilton, with a printout of the software she developed, was the first female programmer in the Apollo program.



HILARY SWIFT FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Mayor Faces Fallout for Oct. 7 Remarks
Denounced by many Jewish New Yorkers and pro-Palestinian protesters, Zohran Mamdani said he had no regrets. Page A17.

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A Long-Awaited Homecoming
The U.S.S. Abraham Lincoln, whose crew endured hardships during its 322 days at sea, arrived in San Diego. PAGE A10

Literature Nobel Goes to Poet
Anne Carson joins Alice Munro and Saul Bellow among Canadian-born writers to receive the prize. PAGE A11



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Trade blockages in the Persian Gulf have reminded the world that there are forces as great as or greater than technology and globalization. PAGE B1

Extended Pause on Trump Ban
A judge extended his block on the president’s effort to bar journalists from the White House, and vowed to decide soon whether to further extend it. PAGE B3

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An Undervalued Overachiever
Breanna Stewart of the Liberty has won everything except the appreciation she deserves, our columnist writes. PAGE B9

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Sam McDowell led the American League in strikeouts five times and posted a single-season high of 325 in 1965. He was 84. PAGE B12

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The Supreme Court heard arguments over whether the Air Force can keep exploding munitions on Guam. PAGE A12

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The president’s plan to enclose a Washington park could alter how the space has been used for generations. PAGE A14



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High-Flying Dramatics
The Georgian folk dancing featured in the Met Opera’s “Macbeth” provides a lot of gravity-defying action. PAGE C1

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Lawrence Freedman PAGE A23

